

Study: Around Half of US Teens Always Online

Nearly half of American teenagers – children ages 13 to 17 - say they are online “constantly” despite concerns about the effects of social media and smartphones on their mental health.

The information comes from a report that was recently released by the Pew Research Center.

As in past years, YouTube was the most popular platform teenagers used. Around 90 percent said they watched videos on the website, down slightly from 95 percent in 2022. Nearly 75 percent of those questioned said they visit YouTube every day.

There was a small downward change in several popular apps teens used. For example, 63 percent of teens said they used TikTok, down from 67 percent. Snapchat use went to 55 percent from 59 percent. This small decline could be due to pandemic-era restrictions easing up and kids having more time to see friends in person. But the change is probably not big enough to be truly meaningful.

FILE - Mikael Makonnen, 18, a freshman at American University, poses for a photo in Washington, D.C, on Saturday, March 2, 2024. (AP Photo/Almaz Abedje, file)

X saw the biggest decline among teenage users. Only 17 percent of teenagers said they use X, down from 23 percent in 2022, the year Elon Musk bought the platform.

Reddit usage remained the same at 14 percent. About 6 percent of teenagers said they use Threads, Meta’s answer to X that launched in 2023.

The report comes as countries around the world try to understand the effects of social media on young people’s well-being.

Australia recently passed a law banning children under 16 from social networks. Still, it is unclear how the Australian government will be able to enforce the age limit. It is also unclear whether such a ban will come with unexpected or bad effects, such as isolating some children.

Meta’s messaging service WhatsApp was different in that it saw the number of teenage users increase to 23 percent from 17 percent in 2022.

Pew also asked teenagers how often they use different online platforms. A small but notable number said they are on them “almost constantly.” For YouTube, 15 percent reported constant use, for TikTok, 16 percent, and for Snapchat, 13 percent.

As in previous public opinion studies, girls were more likely to use TikTok almost constantly while boys went to YouTube. There was no meaningful gender difference in the use of

Snapchat, Instagram and Facebook.

Around 25 percent of Black and Hispanic teens said they visit TikTok almost constantly, compared with just 8 percent of white teenagers.

The report was based on a public opinion study of 1,391 U.S. teenagers that ran from September 18 to October 10, 2024.

I'm John Russell.

Barbara Ortutay reported on this story for the Associated Press. John Russell adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

constantly - adv. ตลอดเวลา, อย่างต่อเนื่อง, สม่ำเสมอ

platform - n. แพลตฟอร์ม (เว็บไซต์หรือแอปพลิเคชันที่เป็นพื้นฐานในการให้บริการ)

app - n. แอปพลิเคชัน (โปรแกรมที่ทำงานเฉพาะอย่าง)

isolate - v. แยกตัว, แยกออกจากกัน, โดดเดี่ยว

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What proportion of American teenagers, aged 13 to 17, report being online "constantly"?

A quarter

Less than one-third

Nearly half

More than three-quarters

2. Which organization released the report mentioned in the article?

The Associated Press

VOA Learning English

The Pew Research Center

American University

3. According to the report, what was the most popular online platform among teenagers?

TikTok

Snapchat

YouTube

X

4. What percentage of teenagers surveyed reported visiting YouTube daily?

95 percent

Approximately 90 percent

Nearly 75 percent

63 percent

5. What trend was observed in the usage of TikTok and Snapchat among teenagers?

Both platforms saw a significant increase.

Both platforms experienced a small decline.

TikTok increased while Snapchat decreased.

Snapchat increased while TikTok decreased.

6. What is suggested as a possible reason for the small decline in TikTok and Snapchat usage?

Increased competition from new apps like Threads.

Concerns about mental health effects of social media.

Teens spending more time seeing friends in person.

A shift towards older, more established platforms.

7. Which platform experienced the most significant decline in teenage users?

TikTok

Snapchat

YouTube

X

8. What is true about the platform 'Threads' according to the article?

It saw a significant increase in teenage users since 2022.

It is Meta's direct competitor to YouTube.

It was launched in 2023 and is used by about 6% of teenagers.

Its usage remained the same as Reddit at 14 percent.

9. The report is released in a global context where countries are trying to understand what specific issue?

The economic impact of social media companies.

The effects of social media on young people's well-being.

The future trends of online platform development.

The privacy implications of data collection.

10. What action has Australia recently taken regarding children and social networks?

It launched a new social media platform for children under 16.

It passed a law banning children under 16 from social networks.

It introduced educational programs about safe social media use for all ages.

It implemented a voluntary age verification system for social media.

11. How did WhatsApp's usage among teenagers change from 2022 to the time of the report?

It saw a decline from 23 percent to 17 percent.

It remained stable at 17 percent.

It increased from 17 percent to 23 percent.

It was not mentioned in the report.

12. Among YouTube, TikTok, and Snapchat, which platform had the highest percentage of teenage users reporting "almost constant" use?

YouTube

TikTok

Snapchat

All three had roughly the same percentage.

13. What gender difference was observed in the "almost constant" use of social media platforms?

Boys were more likely to use Instagram almost constantly.

Girls showed no preference between TikTok and YouTube.

Girls were more likely to use TikTok constantly, while boys favored YouTube.

There were significant gender differences across all platforms mentioned.

14. Which demographic group showed the highest percentage of teenagers visiting TikTok almost constantly?

White teenagers

Asian teenagers

Black and Hispanic teenagers

All groups had similar usage rates.

15. What was the sample size and duration of the public opinion study?

1,391 U.S. adults, conducted over two months.

1,391 U.S. teenagers, conducted from September 18 to October 10, 2024.

1,791 U.S. teenagers, conducted over a full year.

An unspecified number of teenagers, conducted in 2022.